

BLOCK BUSTER
A PVR complex in Jabalpur, MP

MANY EXHIBITORS FEEL THAT CURRENTLY BOLLYWOOD HAS A PAUCITY OF COMPELLING FILMS THAT CAN LURE AUDIENCES BACK TO THE HALLS

to the cinemas. So, there's no hesitation," he says. "A regular audience comes regardless of which film is released. There's penetration of cinemas even in smaller towns."

But all is not hunky-dory even in the hero-worshipping South. If there's a *Tourist Family* (Tamil) or *Thudarum* or *Alappuzha Gymkhana* (both Malayalam) which succeeds, there's also a Kamal Haasan-Mani Ratnam's *Thug Life,* which failed to live up to the hype. Sunil Narang of Asian Cinemas feels some course correction is needed, especially when it comes to aspects such as the theatre-to-streaming release window. In the South, it's just 28 days, compared to 56 days in the Hindi belt. Steep ticket prices as well as those for food and beverage, he feels, are also deterring audiences. "How can we have more screens when existing screens are not running?" he laments. "Where are the movies? Where are the numbers? How will the theatres run?" As many as 30-40 single-screen cinemas in the South have closed in the past six months, he says.

THE BIG PICTURE

If India wants to level up to the markets in China and the United States, what it needs are films that pique audience interest enough for them to make the trip. "There isn't a regular supply of tentpole pictures or big films. They come once every three months; the rest of the time is when we face a downturn," says Pandey, whose MovieMax is looking to expand from 80 to 100 screens by the end of the year. "Once we have a stronger content pipeline, the expectation is that those footfalls will come back. Because people are coming to the cinemas even to watch re-releases and smaller, mid-budget fare like *Munjya* and *12th Fail*."

But even these pleasant surprises are too few and far between. Bijli summarises the cinema theatre business post-pandemic as akin to "feast and famine", wherein a film does exceedingly well only to be followed by a long dry spell where nothing clicks. Yet, he also realises that new cinemas need to come up in smaller centres as opposed to the big cities. Currently, 372 of PVR INOX's 1,743 screens are located in 66 Tier II and Tier III cities and come with a cumulative seating capacity of 80,947. In 2018, the multiplex giant launched the 'franchise owned, company operated' (FOCO) model to take its presence beyond the metros. Adopting an 'asset-light strategy', FOCO has franchise partners who own the property but with PVR INOX handling the design, operations and customer experience. Under this, 42 screens are operating across 12 locations, with 35 more planned in nine new locations, including Shillong, Gangtok and Siliguri.

Meanwhile, Shaikh is hoping to revolutionise the film exhibition market with Janta Cinemas, a business idea that emerged from a simple premise: '*Grahak khada hai, dukaan hi nahin hai* [(The customer is there. But there's no shop in sight)'. He has tied up with the state governments of Assam and Tripura to convert vacant town halls and panchayat houses into 300-seater cinema spaces. While the morning and afternoon hours are devoted to edutainment, the evenings are reserved for films. Tickets are priced at Rs 99 and Shaikh throws in a chai and samosa too.

"What this country needs is cinema halls for the masses. I am planning 10,000 screens in the next two years," he boasts, adding that he is already communicating with the governments of Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Maharashtra and Delhi to launch more Janta properties. "I am converting the pirate audience to the ticketed audience." The ultimate endeavour, he hopes, is that there's a steady maintenance of average collections through modest outlets, which, in turn, helps build a loyal audience. It may not have swanky recliner seats or fancy food and beverage offerings, but what it can ensure is that the show goes on. A houseful one at that. ■